

CHEATSHEET

Psychology of Design

List of cognitive biases & principles that affect your UX



	Name	One-Liner	Category
1.	 Hick's Law	More options leads to harder decisions	Information
2.	 Confirmation Bias	People look for evidence that confirms what they think	Information
3.	 Priming	Previous stimuli influence users' decision	Information
4.	 Cognitive Load	Total amount of mental effort that is required to complete a task	Information
5.	 Anchoring Bias	Users rely heavily on the first piece of information they see	Information
6.	 Nudge	Subtle hints can affect users' decisions	Information
7.	 Progressive Disclosure	Users are less overwhelmed if they're exposed to complex features later	Information
8.	 Fitts's Law	Large and close elements are easier to interact with	Information
9.	 Attentional Bias	Users' thoughts filter what they pay attention to	Information
10.	 Empathy Gap	People underestimate how much emotions influence user behaviors	Information
11.	 Visual Anchors	Elements used to guide users' eyes	Information
12.	 Von Restorff Effect	People notice items that stand out more	Information
13.	 Visual Hierarchy	The order in which people perceive what they see	Information
14.	 Selective Attention	People filter out things from their environment when in focus	Information
15.	 Survivorship Bias	People neglect things that don't make it past a selection process	Information
16.	 Banner Blindness	Users tune out the stuff they get repeatedly exposed to	Information
17.	 Juxtaposition	Elements that are close and similar are perceived as a single unit	Information
18.	 Signifiers	Elements that communicate what they will do	Information
19.	 Contrast	Users' attention is drawn to higher visual weights	Information
20.	 External Trigger	When the information on what to do next is within the prompt itself	Information
21.	 Decoy Effect	Create a new option that's easy to discard	Information

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22.	 <u>Centre-Stage Effect</u>	People tend to choose the middle option in a set of items	<u>Information</u>
23.	 <u>Framing</u>	The way information is presented affects how users make decisions	<u>Information</u>
24.	 <u>Law of Proximity</u>	Elements close to each other are usually considered related	<u>Information</u>
25.	 <u>Tesler's Law</u>	If you simplify too much, you'll transfer some complexity to the users	<u>Information</u>
26.	 <u>Spark Effect</u>	Users are more likely to take action when the effort is small	<u>Information</u>
27.	 <u>Feedback Loop</u>	When users take action, feedback communicates what happened	<u>Information</u>
28.	 <u>Expectations Bias</u>	People tend to be influenced by their own expectations	<u>Information</u>
29.	 <u>Aesthetic-Usability Effect</u>	People perceive designs with great aesthetics as easier to use	<u>Information</u>
30.	 <u>Social Proof</u>	Users adapt their behaviors based on what others do	<u>Meaning</u>
31.	 <u>Scarcity</u>	People value things more when they're in limited supply	<u>Meaning</u>
32.	 <u>Curiosity Gap</u>	Users have a desire to seek out missing information	<u>Meaning</u>
33.	 <u>Mental Model</u>	Users have a preconceived opinion of how things work	<u>Meaning</u>
34.	 <u>Familiarity Bias</u>	People prefer familiar experiences	<u>Meaning</u>
35.	 <u>Halo Effect</u>	People judge things (or people) based on their feelings towards one trait	<u>Meaning</u>
36.	 <u>Miller's Law</u>	Users can only keep 7±2 items in their working memory	<u>Meaning</u>
37.	 <u>Unit Bias</u>	One unit of something feels like the optimal amount	<u>Meaning</u>
38.	 <u>Flow State</u>	Being fully immersed and focused on a task	<u>Meaning</u>
39.	 <u>Skeuomorphism</u>	Users adapt more easily to things that look like real-world objects	<u>Meaning</u>
40.	 <u>Reciprocity</u>	People feel the need to reciprocate when they receive something	<u>Meaning</u>
41.	 <u>Singularity Effect</u>	Users care disproportionately about an individual as compared to a group	<u>Meaning</u>
42.	 <u>Authority Bias</u>	Users attribute more importance to the opinion of an authority figure	<u>Meaning</u>
43.	 <u>Pseudo-Set Framing</u>	Tasks that are part of a group are more tempting to complete	<u>Meaning</u>
44.	 <u>Variable Reward</u>	People especially enjoy unexpected rewards	<u>Meaning</u>
45.	 <u>Group Attractiveness Effect</u>	Individual items seem more attractive when presented in a group	<u>Meaning</u>
46.	 <u>Curse of Knowledge</u>	Not realizing that people don't have the same level of knowledge	<u>Meaning</u>

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47.	 <u>Aha! moment</u>	When new users first realize the value of your product	<u>Meaning</u>
48.	 <u>Self-Initiated Triggers</u>	Users are more likely to interact with prompts they setup for themselves	<u>Meaning</u>
49.	 <u>Survey Bias</u>	Users tend to skew survey answers towards what's socially acceptable	<u>Meaning</u>
50.	 <u>Cognitive Dissonance</u>	It's painful to hold two opposing ideas in our mind	<u>Meaning</u>
51.	 <u>Goal Gradient Effect</u>	Motivation increases as users get closer to their goal	<u>Meaning</u>
52.	 <u>Feedforward</u>	When users know what to expect before they take action	<u>Meaning</u>
53.	 <u>Occam's Razor</u>	Simple solutions are often better than the more complex ones	<u>Meaning</u>
54.	 <u>Noble Edge Effect</u>	Users tend to prefer socially responsible companies	<u>Meaning</u>
55.	 <u>Hawthorne Effect</u>	Users change their behavior when they know they are being observed	<u>Meaning</u>
56.	 <u>Hindsight Bias</u>	People overestimate their ability to predict outcomes after the fact	<u>Meaning</u>
57.	 <u>Law of Similarity</u>	Users perceive a relationship between elements that look similar	<u>Meaning</u>
58.	 <u>Law of Prägnanz</u>	Users interpret ambiguous images in a simpler and more complete form	<u>Meaning</u>
59.	 <u>Streisand Effect</u>	When trying to censor information ends up increasing awareness of that information	<u>Meaning</u>
60.	 <u>Spotlight Effect</u>	People tend to believe they are being noticed more than they really are	<u>Meaning</u>
61.	 <u>Fresh Start Effect</u>	Users are more likely to take action if there's a feeling of new beginnings	<u>Meaning</u>
62.	 <u>Labor Illusion</u>	People value things more when they see the work behind them	<u>Time</u>
63.	 <u>Default Bias</u>	Users tend not to change an established behavior	<u>Time</u>
64.	 <u>Investment Loops</u>	When users invest themselves, they're more likely to come back	<u>Time</u>
65.	 <u>Loss Aversion</u>	People prefer to avoid losses more than earning equivalent gains	<u>Time</u>
66.	 <u>Commitment & Consistency</u>	Users tend to be consistent with their previous actions	<u>Time</u>
67.	 <u>Sunk Cost Effect</u>	Users are reluctant to pull out of something they're invested in.	<u>Time</u>
68.	 <u>Decision Fatigue</u>	Making a lot of decisions lowers users' ability to make rational ones	<u>Time</u>
69.	 <u>Reactance</u>	Users are less likely to adopt a behavior when they feel forced	<u>Time</u>
70.	 <u>Observer-Expectancy Effect</u>	When researchers' biases influence the participants of an experiment	<u>Time</u>

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71.	 Weber's Law	Users adapt better to small incremental changes	<u>Time</u>
72.	 Law of the Instrument	If all you have is a hammer, everything looks like a nail	<u>Time</u>
73.	 Temptation Bundling	Hard tasks are less scary when coupled with something users desire	<u>Time</u>
74.	 Parkinson's Law	The time required to complete a task will take as much time as allowed	<u>Time</u>
75.	 Dunning-Kruger Effect	People tend to overestimate their skills when they don't know much	<u>Time</u>
76.	 Affect Heuristic	People's current emotions cloud and influence their judgment	<u>Time</u>
77.	 Hyperbolic Discounting	People tend to prioritize immediate benefits over bigger future gains	<u>Time</u>
78.	 Chronoception	People's perception of time is subjective	<u>Time</u>
79.	 Cashless Effect	People spend more when they can't actually see the money	<u>Time</u>
80.	 Self-serving bias	People take credits for positive events and blame others if negative	<u>Time</u>
81.	 Pareto Principle	Roughly 80% of the effects come from 20% of the causes	<u>Time</u>
82.	 Discoverability	The ease with which users can discover your features	<u>Time</u>
83.	 Backfire Effect	When people's convictions are challenged, their beliefs get stronger	<u>Time</u>
84.	 False Consensus Effect	People overestimate how much other people agree with them	<u>Time</u>
85.	 Bandwagon Effect	Users tend to adopt beliefs in proportion of others who have already done so	<u>Time</u>
86.	 Second-Order Effect	The consequences of the consequences of actions	<u>Time</u>
87.	 Barnum-Forer Effect	When you believe generic personality descriptions apply specifically to you.	<u>Time</u>
88.	 IKEA Effect	When user partially create something, they value it way more	<u>Time</u>
89.	 Planning Fallacy	People tend to underestimate how much time a task will take	<u>Time</u>
90.	 Provide Exit Points	Invite users to leave your app at the right moment	<u>Memory</u>
91.	 Peak-End Rule	People judge an experience by its peak and how it ends.	<u>Memory</u>
92.	 Sensory Appeal	Users engage more with things appealing to multiple senses	<u>Memory</u>
93.	 Zeigarnik Effect	People remember incomplete tasks better than completed ones	<u>Memory</u>
94.	 Endowment Effect	Users value something more if they feel it's theirs	<u>Memory</u>
95.	 Chunking	People remember grouped information better	<u>Memory</u>

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96.	 <u>Picture Superiority Effect</u>	People remember pictures better than words	<u>Memory</u>
97.	 <u>Method of Loci</u>	People remember things more when they're associated with a location	<u>Memory</u>
98.	 <u>Shaping</u>	Incrementally reinforcing actions to get closer to a target behavior	<u>Memory</u>
99.	 <u>Delighters</u>	People remember more unexpected and playful pleasures	<u>Memory</u>
100.	 <u>Internal Trigger</u>	When users are prompted to take action based on a memory	<u>Memory</u>
101.	 <u>Recognition Over Recall</u>	It's easier to recognize things than recall them from memory	<u>Memory</u>
102.	 <u>Storytelling Effect</u>	People remember stories better than facts alone	<u>Memory</u>
103.	 <u>Negativity Bias</u>	Users recall negative events more than positive ones	<u>Memory</u>
104.	 <u>Availability Heuristic</u>	Users favor recent and available information over past information	<u>Memory</u>
105.	 <u>Spacing Effect</u>	People learn more effectively when study sessions are spaced out	<u>Memory</u>
106.	 <u>Serial Position Effect</u>	It's easier for users to recall the first and last items of a list	<u>Memory</u>



Don't miss the new ones!

We update the list every few weeks here:

<https://growth.design/psychology>.

Don't hesitate to share the link with your friends & colleagues who might enjoy it.

—Dan Benoni & Louis-Xavier Lavallée